

EARLY BUDDHISM

Comprehensive Scholarly Notes — Chapter Five

Source: C. D. Sharma, *A Critical Survey of Indian Philosophy*

Covers: Introduction · Literature & Councils · Four Noble Truths · Noble Eightfold Path · Middle Path ·
Pratītyasamutpāda · Twelve Nidānas · Impermanence · Anātmavāda · Hīnayāna & Mahāyāna ·
Vaibhāṣika & Sautrāntika Metaphysics · Kṣaṇikavāda · Five Skandhas · Nirvāṇa · General Estimate

I. Introduction (pp. 69-70)

A. Portrait of the Buddha and Historical Context

Sharma situates Siddhārtha Gautama in the sixth century BCE, presenting him not merely as a religious founder but as a figure combining:

- **Knowledge** — penetrating insight into the structure of existence
- **Courage** — the willingness to abandon every form of worldly security
- **Sacrifice** — renouncing royal comforts, family affection, and social prestige
- **Compassion** — an orientation toward the welfare of all sentient beings

His defining characteristic was an intense sensitivity to human suffering. Unlike ordinary people who become accustomed to the realities of life, Siddhārtha was profoundly disturbed by the universal facts of:

- Old age — the inevitable decay of the body
- Sickness — the vulnerability of physical existence
- Death — the cessation of all conditioned life

These experiences shattered the apparent happiness and luxury of princely life and forced upon him the question of the meaning of existence. His renunciation was motivated by a desire to discover a *solution* to the universal misery of mankind rather than by personal disappointment or pessimism.

B. The Great Renunciation and Enlightenment

Siddhārtha abandoned not only wealth and privilege but also all ordinary sources of human attachment — royal comforts, family affection, and social prestige. For six years he practiced **severe religious austerities**. Yet these extreme ascetic practices failed to provide the truth he sought. Eventually he attained enlightenment under the Bodhi tree at Gayā, becoming the **Buddha** — 'the Enlightened One'.

C. Buddha as Teacher and the Spread of Buddhism

After enlightenment Buddha dedicated himself to teaching. He preached continuously, travelled extensively, and sought the welfare of all beings. Sharma notes that Buddhism eventually spread from India across much of Asia:

- Ceylon (Sri Lanka), Burma (Myanmar), Siam (Thailand), Malaya, Java, Sumatra
- Nepal, Tibet, Mongolia
- Korea, China, Japan

Thus Buddhism became not merely an Indian sect but a major world religion and culture.

D. Why Buddhism Endures: Three Foundational Doctrines

Sharma argues that the continued vitality of Buddhism rests primarily on three doctrines which remain meaningful because they address *permanent* features of human life rather than temporary historical circumstances:

- **The Four Noble Truths** — diagnosis of the human condition and an account of liberation

- **The Noble Eightfold Path** — practical method for overcoming suffering
- **Pratītyasamutpāda (Dependent Origination)** — philosophical explanation of why suffering exists and how liberation is possible

E. The Buddha's Death and the Conviction of Universal Buddhahood

Sharma closes the introduction by referring to the Buddha's death at Kuśinagara (modern Kasia) at the age of eighty — the event called **Mahāparinirvāṇa**. He remarks that the vivid descriptions of the Buddha's final days demonstrate an important Buddhist conviction:

Every one of us is a potential Buddha. The Buddha is therefore not portrayed as a supernatural exception to humanity but as an example of what human beings can become through spiritual development.

II. Literature (pp. 70-71)

A. Buddha's Attitude Toward Philosophy

One of Sharma's most important observations is that **Buddha was not primarily a metaphysician**. His chief concern was practical: he was an ethical and spiritual teacher before he was a philosopher.

Yet Buddha was not anti-intellectual. Sharma carefully notes that Buddha did discuss metaphysical questions whenever they were connected with practical liberation. He evaluated philosophical views according to a simple criterion: **Do they help remove suffering?** If a theory did not contribute to liberation, Buddha considered it spiritually unprofitable.

B. The Poisoned Arrow Analogy

Buddha illustrates his practical orientation with a famous example. Imagine a man wounded by a poisoned arrow. Before allowing treatment, he insists on knowing:

- Who shot the arrow
- The shooter's caste
- The material of the bow
- The size of the arrow
- The type of poison

Such a person would die before obtaining answers. Likewise, humanity suffers from the poison of old age, disease, and death. The urgent task is to remove suffering, not to indulge in endless metaphysical speculation.

'Two things only, my disciples, do I teach — misery and the cessation of misery.' This concise declaration summarizes the entire orientation of early Buddhism.

C. The Buddhist Councils

Following Buddha's death, his teachings had to be preserved through councils of immense historical importance:

First Buddhist Council

- **Location:** Rājagṛha (Rajgir)
- **Purpose:** To collect and preserve Buddha's teachings. Held shortly after Buddha's death.

Second Buddhist Council

- **Location:** Vaiśālī
- **Purpose:** To settle disputes concerning ten controversial points of monastic discipline. Instead of eliminating disagreement, the council intensified division.
- **Result:** Buddhism split into two major groups — **Sthaviravādins** (the Elders, conservative tendency) and **Mahāsāṅghikas** (the 'Great Community'). This marks the beginning of sectarian differentiation within Buddhism.

Third Buddhist Council

- **Location:** Pāṭaliputra
- **Patron:** Emperor Aśoka
- **Participation:** Approximately one thousand monks
- **Purpose:** To purify the Buddhist community and settle doctrinal disputes.
- **Achievement:** Compilation of the Abhidhamma Piṭaka — the most systematic and analytical effort to organise Buddhist doctrine; the point at which Buddhism begins developing into a sophisticated philosophical tradition.

Fourth Buddhist Council

- **Patron:** King Kaniṣka
- **Date:** First or second century CE
- **Purpose:** To settle doctrinal disagreements of the Sarvāstivādins, one of the most important early Buddhist schools.

D. The Buddhist Canon: Tripiṭaka ('Three Baskets')

The collected scriptures came to be known as the Tripiṭaka. The term 'basket' originally referred to the containers in which the teachings were preserved. The three baskets:

1. Vinaya Piṭaka

The disciplinary code of the Buddhist Order. Contains monastic regulations, rules of conduct, and procedures governing the Saṅgha. Primarily practical and institutional rather than philosophical — its function is to preserve the moral and organizational structure of the Buddhist community.

2. Sutta Piṭaka

Contains the sermons and teachings of the Buddha. The primary source for understanding the historical Buddha's teachings. Divided into five collections (Nikāyas):

- (a) **Dīgha Nikāya** — collection of long discourses
- (b) **Majjhima Nikāya** — collection of middle-length discourses
- (c) **Samyutta Nikāya** — discourses arranged according to subject matter
- (d) **Aṅguttara Nikāya** — discourses arranged numerically
- (e) **Khuddaka Nikāya** — miscellaneous collection containing many important texts

3. Abhidhamma Piṭaka

The most philosophical portion of the canon. Contains systematic analyses of mind, experience, reality, causation, and psychological processes. Where the Suttas are often practical and dialogical, the Abhidhamma is analytical and scholastic.

E. Post-Canonical Literature

Buddhist literary activity did not cease with the formation of the canon. Important later works:

- **Milinda-Pañha** — philosophical discussions between King Milinda (Menander) and the monk Nāgasena. Contains famous arguments regarding personal identity and the doctrine of no-self.
- **Dīpavaṃsa and Mahāvamsa** — historical chronicles especially important for the history of Buddhism in Sri Lanka.
- **Visuddhimagga** — one of the great systematic works of Theravāda Buddhism, providing a comprehensive account of ethics, meditation, wisdom, and liberation.

F. The Emergence of Hinayāna and Mahāyāna

After the Buddha's death, Buddhism gradually developed into different schools. A crucial division arose regarding the status of the Buddha and the interpretation of his teachings.

Hinayāna ('Lesser Vehicle'): insisted that Buddha was fundamentally a human teacher who showed the path but each individual must walk it by personal effort. Literature preserved mainly in **Pāli**.

Mahāyāna ('Greater Vehicle'): increasingly viewed Buddha in exalted terms — transcendent, cosmic, more than merely historical. Developed the Bodhisattva doctrine and cosmic Buddhas, broader devotional traditions. Literature produced mainly in **Sanskrit**.

This 'Literature' section is not merely historical. It explains how Buddhism evolved from the teachings of a single teacher → into a vast philosophical tradition → then into multiple competing schools → each claiming to preserve the authentic meaning of the Buddha. The tensions between Hinayāna and Mahāyāna, realism and idealism, personal and universal salvation are already latent in these historical developments.

III. Teachings of the Buddha (pp. 71-74)

A. Three Central Doctrines

Because the Buddha was primarily an ethical teacher, spiritual guide, and practical reformer rather than a systematic metaphysician, it is difficult to reconstruct his exact philosophical position in every detail. Yet his central teaching can be summarized through three doctrines from which everything else develops:

- (1) The Four Noble Truths
- (2) The Noble Eightfold Path
- (3) The Doctrine of Dependent Origination (Pratītyasamutpāda)

B. The Four Noble Truths

The Buddha's teaching begins not with God, soul, cosmology, or metaphysics, but with an analysis of human existence. The structure follows an almost medical method:

Medical Category	Buddhist Equivalent
Disease	Suffering (Duḥkha)
Cause of disease	Cause of suffering (craving, ignorance)
Cure	Cessation of suffering (Nirvāṇa)
Treatment	Noble Eightfold Path

First Noble Truth: Duḥkha (Suffering)

The first truth states: **There is suffering**. But 'suffering' must not be understood narrowly as physical pain alone. Sharma lists numerous manifestations:

- **Physical**: old age, disease, death
- **Psychological**: fear, grief, anxiety, worry
- **Moral and Social**: greed, hatred, jealousy, quarrels, conflicts, exploitation

These are not accidental features of existence but pervasive characteristics of ordinary worldly life. The Buddha is not saying life contains no happiness — rather, he argues that all conditioned existence is *unstable*. Anything dependent upon changing causes cannot provide permanent satisfaction or lasting security. Therefore suffering is ultimately rooted in **impermanence**.

Second Noble Truth: Cause of Suffering

The second truth asks: Why does suffering exist? Buddha rejects the idea that suffering is causeless — nothing arises without conditions, therefore suffering too must have causes.

Buddhism accepts a **universal causal principle**:

- Every event depends upon conditions
- Nothing exists independently
- Nothing appears without causes
- Nothing persists unchanged — the world is a network of conditioned relations

Since suffering is an event, it must arise from conditions. Therefore: it is produced. And whatever is produced can also *cease*. This insight prepares the way for the Third Noble Truth.

The famous formula: **'This being, that arises.'** Or: 'The cause being present, the effect arises.' This becomes the foundation of Dependent Origination.

Third Noble Truth: Cessation of Suffering

If suffering has causes, then: remove the causes and the effect disappears. Therefore suffering can end. Logical structure:

- (1) Suffering exists
- (2) Suffering has causes
- (3) Remove the causes
- (4) Suffering ceases

Without this doctrine Buddhism would become pessimistic. The First Noble Truth alone could sound pessimistic. But the Third Noble Truth transforms Buddhism into a **path of hope**.

Suffering is not an eternal destiny — liberation is genuinely attainable.

Fourth Noble Truth: The Noble Eightfold Path

The fourth truth answers the practical question: How is suffering removed? The answer is not prayer, ritual, sacrifice, or divine intervention. It is a disciplined transformation of life — the **Āryaṣṭāṅgamārga** (Noble Eightfold Path).

C. The Noble Eightfold Path

The Eight Components

- **1. Right View (Samyag-dṛṣṭi):** Correct understanding of reality — particularly understanding suffering, understanding causality, and understanding the Four Noble Truths.
- **2. Right Resolve (Samyak-saṅkalpa):** Proper intention and determination; cultivation of renunciation, goodwill, and harmlessness.
- **3. Right Speech (Samyag-vāk):** Avoiding lying, slander, abusive language, and idle chatter. Speech should promote truth and harmony.
- **4. Right Action (Samyak-karmānta):** Ethical conduct; avoiding harmful actions and cultivating moral discipline.
- **5. Right Livelihood (Samyag-ājīva):** One's occupation should not harm others. Ethics must extend into economic life.
- **6. Right Effort (Samyag-vyāyāma):** Persistent effort toward moral and spiritual improvement; preventing evil and cultivating good.
- **7. Right Mindfulness (Samyak-smṛti):** Constant awareness of body, feelings, thoughts, and mental states. A disciplined attentiveness to experience.
- **8. Right Concentration (Samyak-samādhi):** Deep meditative absorption; the stabilisation and purification of consciousness.

The Threefold Division of the Path

Sharma notes the eight factors are often grouped into three larger categories — revealing that liberation requires the integrated transformation of all three dimensions:

Category	Sanskrit Term	Path Factors Included
Wisdom	Prajñā	Right View, Right Resolve
Morality	Śīla	Right Speech, Right Action, Right Livelihood
Meditation	Samādhi	Right Effort, Right Mindfulness, Right Concentration

Philosophical significance: Knowledge alone is insufficient. Morality alone is insufficient. Meditation alone is insufficient. All three must work together as an integrated discipline of intellectual, ethical, and psychological transformation.

D. The Middle Path (Madhyamā Pratipad)

Before explaining causation, Buddha first explains the proper way of life. Two extremes are rejected:

1. Self-Indulgence (Rejected)

A life devoted to sensual pleasure, luxury, enjoyment, and gratification of desires. Buddha rejects this because it strengthens attachment and dependence on transient things. It produces desire, dependence, attachment, and slavery to pleasure. Such a life cannot lead to liberation.

2. Self-Mortification (Rejected)

Severe austerities, bodily torture, extreme asceticism, suppression of natural needs. Buddha rejected this too because he had personally practiced it for years and found that it did not produce enlightenment. It produces suffering, weakness, obsession with the body, and spiritual sterility.

The Middle Path Discovered

The Buddha discovered a path between these extremes, cultivating healthy living, ethical conduct, meditation, and wisdom. Instead of obsessing over pleasure or pain, it directs attention toward liberation. Buddhism becomes neither hedonistic nor ascetic — it becomes a **discipline of balance**.

E. Pratītyasamutpāda (Dependent Origination)

Sharma regards Pratītyasamutpāda as one of the most important doctrines in Buddhism and the foundation upon which most Buddhist doctrines rest. It is contained in the Second and Third Noble Truths because it explains why suffering exists, how suffering arises, and how suffering ceases.

Literal Meaning

- *Pratītya* = depending upon
- *Samutpāda* = arising
- Therefore: '**everything arises depending upon conditions**'. Nothing exists independently. Nothing is self-caused. Nothing is absolutely isolated.

The Universal Principle

'This being, that becomes.' / 'The cause being present, the effect arises.' Conversely: Remove the cause — the effect disappears. This is not merely a statement about physical causation. It is a universal law governing psychological events, moral events, social events, rebirth, suffering, and liberation.

Two Standpoints on Pratītyasamutpāda

1. Relative/Empirical Standpoint: Everything is conditioned, dependent, finite, relative, and subject to birth and death. Nothing possesses independent existence — the world is a network of interdependent relations.

2. Absolute Standpoint: Sharma introduces a more philosophical interpretation — *Saṃsāra* and *Nirvāṇa* are not two absolutely different realities. Both are aspects of the same Reality viewed differently. When Reality appears through conditions: it is *Saṃsāra*. When Reality is viewed free from conditions: it is *Nirvāṇa*.

This interpretation reflects Sharma's tendency to read Buddhism through categories familiar from later Indian philosophy, especially discussions about the Absolute and appearance.

Pratītyasamutpāda as Metaphysical Middle Path

Sharma makes a crucial claim: Pratītyasamutpāda is not merely a theory of causation — it is also a **metaphysical Middle Path**:

- **Rejects Eternalism**: the view that something exists eternally and independently
- **Rejects Nihilism**: the view that nothing exists at all
- Instead: reality is understood as conditioned, dependent, and relational. Things are neither absolutely real nor absolutely unreal.

Enlightenment as Insight into Dependent Origination

Sharma states something striking: the enlightenment attained under the Bodhi tree was essentially an insight into this law of dependent origination. The Buddha understood how suffering arises, how suffering persists, and how suffering can end. Thus enlightenment was not primarily a mystical vision but an **understanding of the causal structure of existence**.

IV. The Twelve Links of Dependent Origination — Dvādaśa Nidānas (pp. 73-74)

A. Overview and the Chain

The Dvādaśa Nidānas (Twelve Links) explain the origin of suffering, the continuity of rebirth, the operation of karma, the structure of worldly existence, and the possibility of liberation. This doctrine is a detailed application of the general principle of Pratītyasamutpāda. The chain is not merely a chronological story — it is a **causal analysis of existence itself**.

The Forward Chain (Arising of Suffering)

1. Avidyā (Ignorance)

The entire cycle begins with ignorance — not ordinary lack of education, but ignorance of the true nature of reality: impermanence, suffering, and the absence of a permanent self. Because beings misunderstand reality, they become attached to things as though they were permanent and capable of providing lasting satisfaction.

2. Saṃskāra (Karmic Dispositions)

Ignorance generates actions. These actions leave behind tendencies, impressions, and dispositions — karmic formations that shape future experience. Thus ignorance becomes embodied in habits of thought and action.

3. Vijñāna (Consciousness)

Karmic formations condition consciousness — the stream of awareness that continues through the process of rebirth. The point is not that an eternal soul passes from one life to another. Rather, causal continuity persists through the conditioning force of prior karmic formations.

4. Nāma-rūpa (Name-and-Form)

Consciousness conditions psycho-physical existence. *Nāma* (mental side): ideas, feelings, perceptions, intentions. *Rūpa* (physical side): bodily existence, material form. Together they constitute the psycho-physical organism.

5. *Ṣaḍāyatana (Six Sense Bases)*

From psycho-physical existence arise the six sense organs: Eye, Ear, Nose, Tongue, Body, and Mind. The inclusion of mind as a sense-organ is a distinctive Buddhist feature — mind is treated as another avenue through which objects are experienced, not as the seat of a self.

6. *Sparsā (Contact)*

When a sense organ, an object, and consciousness come together, contact occurs. Contact is the meeting point of subject and object — the moment experiential engagement begins.

7. *Vedanā (Feeling)*

Contact produces feeling. Feelings may be pleasant, unpleasant, or neutral. This is a crucial stage because emotional responses begin here — experience becomes affectively charged.

8. *Tṛṣṇā (Craving)*

Feeling generates craving. Pleasant feelings produce desire for continuation; painful feelings produce desire for escape; neutral feelings often generate subtle forms of attachment. Craving is one of the most important concepts in Buddhism because it directly fuels suffering.

9. *Upādāna (Clinging)*

Craving intensifies into attachment. One no longer merely desires — one grasps, identifying oneself with possessions, beliefs, relationships, ambitions, and experiences. Attachment deepens bondage.

10. *Bhava (Becoming)*

Clinging produces becoming. Bhava refers to the process through which karmic forces generate future existence. A person continually creates the conditions of future life through attachment and action.

11. *Jāti (Birth)*

Becoming culminates in birth. A new existence emerges and the cycle begins again.

12. *Jarā-maraṇa (Old Age and Death)*

Birth inevitably leads to old age, decay, and death. Along with these come sorrow, lamentation, grief, and despair. Thus the cycle of suffering is completed.

B. The Reverse Process: Cessation Chain

The doctrine is not merely explanatory — it is also liberating. If the chain can operate forward, it can also operate backward:

- If **ignorance ceases** → karmic formations cease
- If karmic formations cease → consciousness ceases
- If consciousness ceases → psycho-physical existence ceases
- ... and so on through the entire chain until ...
- Birth ceases → old age ceases → death ceases → **suffering ceases**

This is the practical significance of the doctrine: it shows the path to liberation through the systematic removal of conditions.

C. The Ultimate Root: Avidyā

The entire chain finally terminates in Avidyā (Ignorance). This is not ignorance of information or science but ignorance of the true nature of existence — of impermanence, suffering, and no-self. This is why knowledge later becomes the key to liberation.

From Dependent Origination follow: suffering, karma, rebirth, impermanence, no-self, and liberation. Pratītyasamutpāda functions for Buddhism somewhat like Brahman functions for Vedānta or substance functions for Aristotle — it is the central explanatory principle of the system.

D. The Doctrine of Impermanence (Anityavāda)

Since everything depends on causes and conditions, nothing is permanent. Anything that arises because of causes exists only temporarily, changes continuously, and eventually disappears. Therefore permanence is impossible within conditioned existence.

E. Anātmavāda (No-Self): From Impermanence to the Denial of the Self

If everything is changing, what about the self? Can there be an eternal, unchanging soul? According to Sharma, Buddhism answers: **No**. A permanent self would have to be independent, immutable, and self-identical. But experience reveals only changing processes. Therefore Buddhism rejects the doctrine of an eternal self (Ātman).

This is one of the most revolutionary doctrines in world philosophy. The person is not a permanent substance. What we call a 'person' is merely a collection of changing processes. There is continuity, but not identity. There is causal succession, but not an eternal soul. This doctrine directly challenges the dominant Upaniṣadic conception of Ātman.

The conceptual backbone:



V. Hīnayāna and Mahāyāna (pp. 75-76)

A. Why the Division Occurred

As Buddhism spread and developed, different understandings of the Buddha and his teachings emerged. The central question gradually became: **What is the highest spiritual ideal?** The answer given to this question led to the distinction between Hīnayāna and Mahāyāna. Sharma is careful to emphasise that both claim fidelity to the Buddha, yet they interpret his message differently.

B. The Hīnayāna Ideal: The Arhat

For Hīnayāna Buddhists, the highest ideal is the **Arhat** — one who has:

- Destroyed ignorance
- Eliminated craving
- Attained Nirvāṇa
- Escaped the cycle of rebirth

The emphasis is on **personal liberation**. The individual must purify himself through moral discipline, meditation, and wisdom. No one can liberate another — each person must walk the path himself. Characteristics of the Hīnayāna spirit:

- **Self-Effort**: liberation depends upon one's own practice
- **Historical Buddha**: Buddha is viewed primarily as a human teacher who discovered the path and showed it to others
- **Monastic Ideal**: the religious life is centred around discipline and renunciation
- **Individual Salvation**: the principal concern is the liberation of the practitioner himself

C. The Mahāyāna Ideal: The Bodhisattva

Mahāyāna thinkers felt that the Arhat ideal was incomplete. Their criticism was not that liberation is wrong — rather, that concern solely for one's own liberation lacks sufficient compassion. A truly enlightened being should seek the welfare of all creatures.

The highest ideal therefore becomes the **Bodhisattva** — one who:

- Possesses wisdom and is capable of entering Nirvāṇa
- Yet postpones final liberation
- In order to help all sentient beings attain liberation

Mahāyāna places enormous emphasis on **Karuṇā (Compassion)** and **Prajñā (Wisdom)** together. Wisdom without compassion is incomplete; compassion without wisdom is blind. The Bodhisattva embodies both simultaneously. This marks perhaps the most important difference:

- **Hīnayāna**: seeks individual liberation
- **Mahāyāna**: seeks universal liberation — the spiritual destiny of all beings becomes the concern of the enlightened person

D. The Transformation of the Buddha

Another major difference concerns the status of the Buddha himself:

- **Hīnayāna View**: Buddha is primarily an extraordinary human being, a teacher, an enlightened guide. Though revered, he remains fundamentally human.
- **Mahāyāna View**: The Buddha increasingly acquires a transcendent character — he becomes cosmic, universal, almost divine. The historical Gautama is viewed as only one manifestation of a deeper Buddhahood.

Religious consequences: Bodhisattva worship, the increased importance of faith and grace, and devotional practices. Thus Mahāyāna became more accessible to ordinary people than the highly disciplined monastic path of Hīnayāna.

E. Comparative Summary

Dimension	Hīnayāna	Mahāyāna
Ideal figure	Arhat	Bodhisattva
Goal	Personal liberation	Universal liberation
View of Buddha	Historical human teacher	Cosmic, transcendent being
Emphasis	Self-effort	Compassion (Karuṇā) + Wisdom
Orientation	Monastic, conservative	Broader religious appeal
Language	Pāli	Sanskrit

This division reveals two fundamentally different answers to a profound ethical question: What should an enlightened person do after attaining wisdom? Hīnayāna: attain Nirvāṇa and end the cycle of suffering. Mahāyāna: remain engaged with the world until all beings are liberated. The tension between wisdom and compassion, personal perfection and service to others, becomes one of the defining themes of later Buddhist philosophy.

VI. Metaphysics of Hīnayāna: Vaibhāṣika and Sautrāntika (pp. 77-80)

A. The Fundamental Principle: Universal Impermanence (Anityatā)

The starting point of Hīnayāna metaphysics is the doctrine of **Anityatā (Impermanence)**. Everything in the world arises, changes, and disappears. Nothing remains fixed, eternal, or unchanged. This doctrine is derived directly from Dependent Origination: whatever depends upon causes comes into existence, undergoes change, and eventually ceases. Therefore permanence is impossible in the conditioned world. The Vaibhāṣikas and Sautrāntikas share this fundamental framework though they differ in important epistemological details.

B. Kṣaṇikavāda (Theory of Momentariness)

The Vaibhāṣikas push the doctrine of impermanence to its logical conclusion. They argue:

- If things truly change, they cannot remain numerically identical through time.
- Consequently: **everything exists only for a single moment (kṣaṇa)**.
- A thing does not endure, persist, or continue unchanged. It flashes into existence and immediately perishes.
- Every moment is a new event. Reality is therefore a succession of momentary entities rather than a collection of enduring substances.

The reasoning: Suppose something remains exactly the same — then no real change has occurred. But change undeniably occurs. Therefore things must be continuously replaced by new states. The world is not a collection of permanent objects; it is a stream of momentary occurrences.

The Three Analogies

- **The River Analogy:** A river appears permanent — we call it 'the Ganges', 'the Yamuna'. Yet the water is constantly changing. The river seems identical only because of continuity. Its permanence is apparent rather than real.
- **The Flame Analogy:** A flame appears continuous, yet at every moment fuel is consumed, combustion occurs anew, and a new flame replaces the previous one. Continuity creates the illusion of identity.
- **The Wheel Analogy:** A rapidly spinning wheel appears stationary or unified. Closer inspection reveals constant movement and change — what appears stable is a succession of fleeting states.

C. The Denial of Substance

This theory has radical consequences. Most philosophical systems assume a substance, an underlying entity, something that remains the same through change. The Buddhists reject this. **There is no hidden permanent substance beneath appearances.** Reality consists only of momentary events — nothing more is needed.

D. Anātmavāda (No-Self) Revisited in Metaphysical Context

If everything is momentary, what about the person? The Buddhist answer: the person is not an enduring soul — the person is a stream of changing psycho-physical events. There is continuity, but no permanent identity. Thus Buddhism rejects the Upaniṣadic doctrine of Ātman.

E. The Five Skandhas (Five Aggregates)

The Buddhist analysis of personality is carried out through the doctrine of the **Pañca Skandhas**. What we call a 'person' is merely a collection of five aggregates. There is no additional self behind them:

- **1. Rūpa (Form):** The material aspect; the physical body
- **2. Vedanā (Feeling):** Experiences of pleasure, pain, and neutrality
- **3. Saṃjñā (Perception):** Recognition and conceptual identification
- **4. Saṃskāra (Mental Formations):** Volitions, tendencies, habits, and dispositions
- **5. Vijñāna (Consciousness):** Awareness itself

The Buddhist argument: when we examine experience carefully, we find only these aggregates. We never encounter a separate self apart from them. The supposed ego is therefore a **conceptual construction** — not an independently existing reality.

F. Nāgasena's Chariot Argument

Nāgasena asks: Where exactly is the chariot? Is it the wheels? The axle? The frame? The yoke? None of these individually is the chariot. Yet apart from them there is no chariot. The word 'chariot' merely designates a collection of parts arranged in a certain way.

Likewise: 'person' is merely a convenient designation for the aggregates. There is no independent self beyond them. Buddhism does not say that nothing exists — this is a common misunderstanding. What exists are processes. What does not exist is a permanent, unchanging substance. The self is denied, not experience itself.

G. Vaibhāṣika Realism vs. Sautrāntika Differences

- **Vaibhāṣika**: holds that external objects genuinely exist. Both physical entities and mental entities are real momentary events. They are realists, though not substance realists.
- **Sautrāntika**: agrees with impermanence, momentariness, and no-self, but is more cautious about direct realism and places greater emphasis on inference in our knowledge of external objects.

Sharma treats these differences briefly because his main concern is the shared metaphysical framework. The core argument structure:

Dependent Origination → Impermanence → Momentariness → No Permanent Substance → No Permanent Self

This is the philosophical backbone of Hīnayāna metaphysics. Most philosophical systems begin with substances, essences, and enduring selves. Buddhism begins instead with events, processes, relations, and causal continuity. The world becomes a flowing stream rather than a collection of fixed things.

VII. Nirvāṇa (pp. 81-82)

A. The Meaning of Nirvāṇa

After discussing suffering, causation, impermanence, momentariness, and no-self, Sharma arrives at the ultimate goal of Buddhism: **Nirvāṇa**. The entire Buddhist path is directed toward its attainment. Yet Nirvāṇa is notoriously difficult to describe because it lies beyond ordinary worldly experience.

The literal meaning of Nirvāṇa is often explained as 'blowing out' or 'extinction' — the metaphor of a flame being extinguished. But Sharma emphasises that this should not be interpreted superficially. The crucial question is: **What exactly is extinguished?**

The Buddhist answer: what is extinguished is **craving (tṛṣṇā)**, **attachment (upādāna)**, and **ignorance (avidyā)** — the causes of suffering, not some positive entity.

B. Negative Descriptions of Nirvāṇa

Early Buddhism frequently describes Nirvāṇa negatively:

- Cessation, extinction, freedom from suffering
- Ending of desire, ending of rebirth
- Not craving, not bondage, not suffering, not becoming

This negative language arises because Nirvāṇa is defined partly by what it is not.

C. Is Nirvāṇa Mere Annihilation?

This is a natural objection. Sharma insists that Buddhism does not intend such a crude doctrine. The extinction involved is not the destruction of some substantial self, because Buddhism already denies such a self. What ceases is the causal process that generates suffering and rebirth — not some positive entity.

D. Positive Descriptions of Nirvāṇa

Although Buddhist texts often use negative language, they also employ positive expressions. Nirvāṇa is described as:

- **Peace** — the supreme cessation of inner conflict
- **Bliss** — not sensory pleasure but the freedom from the anxieties of worldly existence
- **Fearlessness** — liberation from the insecurity of conditioned existence
- **The Highest Good** — the supreme state of freedom

Sharma notes an important philosophical problem: Nirvāṇa transcends ordinary experience and language is generally suited to describing things within experience. Consequently, descriptions of Nirvāṇa are inevitably indirect. This explains why Buddhist texts oscillate between negative and positive language — both are attempts to point toward a reality that cannot be fully captured in ordinary concepts.

E. The Arhat and Nirvāṇa

For Hīnayāna Buddhism, the ideal spiritual figure is the Arhat who has destroyed ignorance, uprooted desire, escaped rebirth, and attained Nirvāṇa. Nirvāṇa is therefore not merely a theory — it is the existential culmination of the entire Buddhist path.

Nirvāṇa completes the structure established by the Four Noble Truths:

Suffering → Cause of Suffering → Removal of Cause → Liberation (Nirvāṇa)

The entire Buddhist system is therefore organised around a therapeutic goal rather than a speculative one.

VIII. General Estimate of Early Buddhism (pp. 82-83)

A. Sharma's Standpoint

This is Sharma's own philosophical assessment of Buddhism — one of the most important sections because here he moves from exposition to criticism. As throughout the book, his standpoint is broadly sympathetic but also strongly influenced by Vedānta. He credits Buddhism with immense contributions before raising his objections.

B. First Appreciation: Buddhism's Genuine Achievements

- Penetrating analysis of suffering and its psychological roots
- Powerful ethical vision — the attack on attachment and selfishness
- Profound psychological insight into the nature of experience and desire
- Rejection of dogmatic metaphysics in favour of critical analysis
- Emphasis on causality and impermanence as explanatory principles
- Emphasis on compassion and self-discipline as spiritual values

C. The Problem of Extreme Momentariness (Kṣaṇikavāda)

Sharma's first major criticism concerns Kṣaṇikavāda. If everything exists for only a single moment, several serious difficulties arise:

1. The Problem of Recognition

When we recognise something, we often say: 'This is the same object I saw yesterday.' Recognition appears to require continuity between the past and present encounter. But if the object of yesterday and the object of today are entirely different momentary entities, how can recognition occur? The continuity necessary for recognition seems to presuppose some form of enduring relation.

2. The Problem of Memory

Memory also becomes problematic. Remembering seems to presuppose some enduring relation between past experience and present awareness. If both moments are entirely disconnected, memory becomes difficult to explain without some principle of continuity.

3. The Problem of Karma

A famous and widely-noted criticism. Buddhism teaches no permanent self and momentary existence, yet it also teaches karma — that actions produce results. Sharma asks: if the person who performs an action no longer exists (having perished in the very next moment), who receives the result? The continuity required by karma appears difficult to reconcile with radical momentariness.

4. The Problem of Liberation

A related issue. If there is no enduring self:

- **Who is bound?**
- **Who is liberated?**

The Buddhist answer appeals to causal continuity rather than substantial identity. But Sharma believes this solution leaves philosophical difficulties unresolved.

5. The Problem of Knowledge

Knowledge seems to involve synthesis. For example: when we perceive a moving object, we combine many successive perceptions into a single coherent experience. Such synthesis appears to require some enduring principle of unity. Sharma doubts whether strict momentariness can adequately explain this synthetic unity of experience.

D. Sharma's Central Critique

The heart of his criticism can be summarised as follows:

Buddhism successfully demolishes the notion of a permanent empirical ego — that is a genuine philosophical achievement. However, Sharma believes Buddhism goes too far when it denies every form of enduring self whatsoever. In attacking a false self, it may have eliminated the possibility of a true self as well.

The Vedāntic background: For Vedānta, changing mental states cannot explain unity, continuity presupposes an underlying witness, and knowledge presupposes a knower. Thus Sharma finds Buddhist no-self theory ultimately unsatisfactory from a Vedāntic perspective.

E. Final Balanced Judgment

Strengths (Buddhism's genuine achievements)

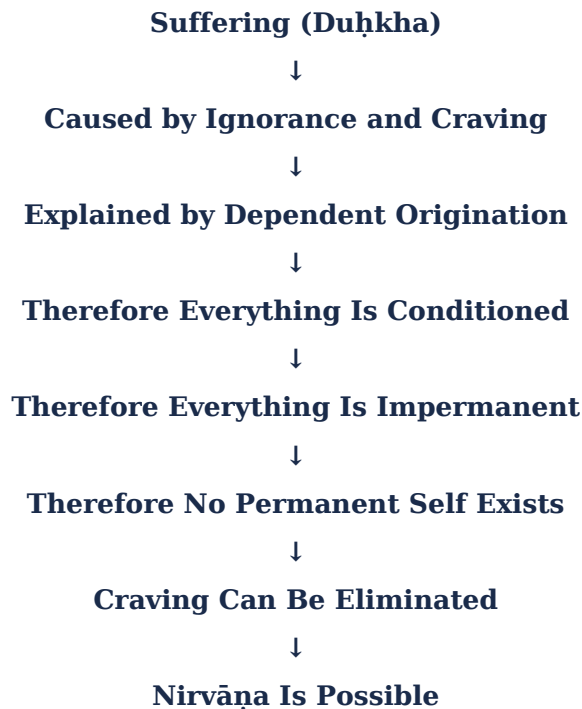
- Penetrating analysis of suffering, its causes, and its cessation
- Powerful ethical vision and emphasis on compassion and self-discipline
- Profound psychological insight into desire, attachment, and ego
- Rejection of dogmatic metaphysics
- Profound emphasis on causality and impermanence

Weaknesses (according to Sharma)

- Difficulty explaining continuity — the stream of experience must have some principle of unity
- Difficulty explaining memory — no disconnected moments can account for retrospective awareness
- Difficulty explaining karma — action and result require some form of continuity of agent
- Difficulty explaining liberation — bondage and freedom presuppose some subject who is bound and freed
- Difficulty explaining knowledge — synthesis of perception requires an enduring principle of unity

F. The Chapter as One Conceptual Map

The entire chapter can be reduced to a single chain of reasoning:



Sharma's critique is equally concise: Buddhism brilliantly explains change, but struggles to explain continuity. That tension — between flux and continuity, process and identity, impermanence and responsibility — is the central philosophical problem Sharma sees in Early Buddhism. The next Buddhist chapters (especially on Mādhyamika Śūnyavāda and Yogācāra/Vijñānavāda) can be read as attempts to push, refine, or solve problems already implicit in these early doctrines.

End of Chapter Five Notes — Early Buddhism

Source: C. D. Sharma, A Critical Survey of Indian Philosophy, Chapter 5, pp. 69–83